

ibility, large-area manufacturing and potential low-cost in volume."

According to Cantarella, for printed and flexible electronics, the most challenging sector will be medical. He says, "The devices included in this field should be bio-compatible and sufficiently reliable for medical care in order to be able to generally improve healthcare and monitor physical conditions."

"Even more challenging is the idea to implant such devices for real-time analysis such as digestible electronic components that can be dissolved in the human body," adds Cantarella.

Pragmatic Printing holds a great deal of potential for the production of new exciting applications within the packaging sector and the development of the IoT.

Bagshaw notes, "The company is developing ultra-thin and low-cost flexible microcircuits that can be easily incorporated into mass-market

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packaging, and will revolutionise everyday living by providing consumers with real-time information about every aspect of their environment."

He adds, "Hybrid electronics will give rise to a wide range of new, novel applications such as flexible displays for mobile devices, smart therapeutic bandages for managing and monitoring recovery of wounds, wearable electronics for

monitoring and improving performance, wireless medical devices for rapid diagnostics using printed sensors, conformable lighting and intelligent packaging for consumer goods and industrial products, to name a few."

At a printed electronics conference in the USA, it was predicted that the overall market for printed and flexible sensors is forecast to be worth over US\$ 7 billion by 2020. ●

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